

CHALLENGES AHEAD



INFRASTRUCTURE GAPS:

Lack of quality roads, housing, and utilities



ENVIRONMENTAL DEGRADATION:

Pollution, traffic, and resource depletion



SKILL MISMATCH:

Inadequate workforce skills for emerging industries



SOCIAL INEQUALITY:

Disparities in access to services and opportunities



UNSUSTAINABLE GROWTH:

Lack of balanced economic, social, and environmental development

Besides, the city will also be part of the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, also known as the Delhi-Mumbai National Corridor.

88 | Thanks to these developments, the city's real estate sector has been booming for the past five years. According to Darshak Shah, Director of the real estate company Fortune Dream-Con, 20-25 residential and commercial projects are underway in the city, all located near where the bullet train is set to come up. Vapi will also be part of the global logistics company DP World's rail freight service between Hazira port in Surat and Delhi-NCR.

Historically, Vapi has been an industrial town because of its proximity to the dam near the city and connectivity to Mumbai, says Satish Patel, President of the Vapi Industries Association. The key industries in the area include chemicals, paper mills, textiles, and pharmaceuticals. The key players in the region's chemical sector include UPL, Pidilite, and Aarti Industries.

The Gujarat government, too, is leaving no stone unturned in giving Vapi a boost. It recently notified nine new municipal corporations, and Vapi was one of them.

Tirunelveli

It takes about two and a half hours from Madurai airport to reach Tirunelveli, going past picturesque windmill parks and several temples. This is a region known for its agricultural prowess and cement plants and, like most parts of Tamil Nadu, has a strong retail base. Once you get off the highway and enter Tirunelveli, one of the first things that catches your attention is the number of jewellery stores.

Money from agriculture makes its way into real estate

and jewellery, both considered safe investments in this part of the world. "Gold has attained an international currency status post the pandemic. The emphasis on savings in gold is a big trend here," says B. Ramesh, Joint Managing Director, Thangamayil Jewellery, a listed entity that owns three stores in Tirunelveli district.

Thangamayil Jewellery entered the town eight years ago, seeing the high disposable incomes there. "During that period, we saw a large number of women turning into entrepreneurs or becoming employees in factories. What they saved needed to be channelled, and gold was the preferred instrument," Ramesh says.

Since the pandemic, customers purchased 8 gm of gold on average, and Ramesh says that has now jumped to 12 gm. "Agriculture is a reliable source of livelihood in Tirunelveli, and people do not spend beyond their basic requirements. There is no mall culture, and money has easily flowed into land and gold," he explains.

A short 20-km drive from Tirunelveli leads to Gangaikondan, home to the Small Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu (SIPCOT) Industrial Park. Initially created with 2,000 acres, the government plans to acquire another 1,500 acres to enlarge it. It is home to Tata Power Solar's photovoltaic (PV) and module manufacturing unit. Here, the 2,800-strong workforce has upwards of 60% women representation. This is a big-ticket project with a capacity of 4.3 GW each for cells and modules.

The sophisticated shop floor has multiple robots at work and is a world-class operation. It has benefitted from an existing base of educational institutions—technical and non-technical—that provides factories with quality labour.